

FAITH AND THE KINGDOM OF GOD

DAVID LUFF

PART ONE

Faith is the foundation and root of Christianity. Salvation by faith alone in the complete work of Christ apart from any works of man is the truth that separates Christianity from all other religions which either all or in part depend on man's human effort to make himself good. There is no phase of our Christian experience in which faith is not the critical component. In the way of introduction, following are a few scriptures that bear out this truth:

*"But without **faith** it is impossible to please Him (God), for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him"* (Hebrews 11:6, NKJV).

*"But he who doubts is condemned if he eats, because he does not eat from **faith**; for whatever is not from **faith** is sin"* (Romans 14:23, NKJV).

*"Now the just shall live by **faith**; but if anyone draws back, My soul has no pleasure in him"* (Hebrews 10:38, NKJV).

"I have been crucified with Christ; it is no longer I who live, but

*Christ lives in me; and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by **faith** in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me"* (Galatians 2:20, NKJV).

*"For we walk by **faith**, not by sight"* (2 Corinthians 5:7, NKJV).

What is faith? Hebrews 11:1 gives us a definition of faith, and I would like to quote it from the Amplified Bible: *"Now faith is the assurance (title deed, confirmation) of things hoped for (divinely guaranteed), and the evidence of things not seen [the conviction of their reality—faith comprehends as fact what cannot be experienced by the physical senses]."* Faith is the divine guarantee from God that the things we hope for but which have not become reality are as real for us today as if they had already taken place. Faith also provides us with the ability to understand things in the spiritual realm which we cannot experience with our physical senses.

The Greek word for faith is *pistis* which means to be persuaded, come to trust. For the believer, faith is God's divine persuasion and therefore is different from human belief. Faith is always

received from God and is never generated through self-will. It cannot be worked up by our human effort. God has not created within our human natures the faith to believe for salvation (or any other spiritual truth for that matter). It is God's gift to us which persuades us to believe in Christ for salvation. See Ephesians 2:8-9, "*For by grace you have been saved through **faith**, and that not of yourselves; it is the gift of God, not of works, lest anyone should boast*" (NKJV). "*But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, longsuffering, gentleness, goodness, **faith**, meekness, temperance: against such there is no law*" (Galatians 5:22-23, NKJV). Faith, along with the other graces listed in this scripture, does not come from our own natural efforts to generate it but is developed in us by the work of the Holy Spirit. The Apostle Paul testified to God's persuasion of him to believe in Romans 8:38-39, "*For **I am persuaded** that neither death nor life, nor angels nor principalities nor powers, nor things present nor things to come, nor height nor depth, nor any other created thing, shall be able to separate us from the love of God which is in Christ Jesus our Lord*" (NKJV). Paul is saying that God persuaded him, or imparted faith into his heart, to believe that nothing that one could imagine could ever separate him from God's love for him which is in Christ Jesus. That truth became faith to him.

Faith and human belief are really two different things although biblically they are sometimes used interchangeably in the Bible. Faith always precedes human belief. God births faith into our hearts, and our response is to believe. The word for "believes" is *pisteuo* (Gk) which is a combination of the word *pistis* (Gk) (faith) and *peitho* (Gk) which means to **persuade oneself** (believe) and which finally means **faith-believing** (from Strongs). It is like this, God gifts us with a measure of faith as we hear the word of God. As we intently meditate on the word and, so to speak, eat it, we become persuaded of the truth of it and the power in it. In other words, we **believe** it.

I like the way Galatians 3:5 is stated in the Amplified Bible, "*So then, does He who supplies you with His [marvelous Holy] Spirit and works miracles among you, do it as a result of the works of the Law [which you perform], or because you [believe confidently in the message which you] heard with faith?*" The following scripture is such a good companion for the one above, "*So then faith comes by hearing, and the ear to hear by the word of God.* (Romans 10:17, Jubilee). The faith necessary to believe comes by hearing the word of God as it is preached to us and as we read it from the Bible. And miraculously, the word of God itself provides us with the "spiritual ears" to hear it in such a way that it imparts faith to our hearts. As we meditate on that word, our belief in it becomes stronger and stronger. The faith that God gifts to us is firm and never wavers. It is our belief that is sometimes strong and sometimes weak. That is why it is so important for us to meditate on the truth that God speaks into our hearts through His word. "*Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and comes down from the Father of lights, **with whom there is no variation or shadow of turning***" (James 1:17, NKJV).

Faith and God's will are connected in Scripture. "*And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that you may prove what is that **good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God.** For I say, through the grace*

*given unto me, to every man that is among you, not to think of himself more highly than he ought to think; but to think soberly, **according as God hath dealt to every man the measure of faith***" (Romans 12:2-3, NKJV).

We can and should pursue faith. "*For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evil, for which some have strayed from the faith in their greediness and pierced themselves through with many sorrows. But you, O man of God, flee these things and **pursue** righteousness, godliness, **faith**, love, patience, gentleness.* (1 Timothy 6:10-11, NKJV).

*Flee also youthful lusts; but **pursue** righteousness, **faith**, love, peace with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart* (2 Timothy 2:22, NKJV).

God's gift of faith is critically important in our coming to Christ. "*No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him (or divinely persuades him, imparts to him the faith to believe); and I will raise him up at the last day*" (John 6:44, NKJV). "*For God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son, that whoever believes in Him should not perish but have everlasting life*" (John 3:16, NKJV).

The very basis of our justification before God comes through faith. "*For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, being justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus. Therefore, we conclude that a man is **justified by faith** apart from the deeds of the law*" (Romans 3:23-24, 28, NKJV). "*Knowing that a man is not justified by the works of the law but by **faith in Jesus Christ**, even we have believed in Christ Jesus, that we might be **justified by faith in Christ** and not by the works of the law; for by the works of the law no flesh shall be justified*" (Galatians 2:16, NKJV).

Our sanctification which is our being transformed into the likeness of Jesus is also accomplished through faith in Christ. "*O foolish Galatians! Who has bewitched you that you should not obey the truth, before whose eyes Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed among you as crucified? This only I want to learn from you: Did you receive the Spirit by the works of the law, or by the hearing of faith? Are you so foolish? Having begun in the Spirit, are you now being made perfect by the flesh*" (Galatians 3:1-3, NKJV)? The process of our sanctification is often referred to as a walk, and we are instructed to walk by faith. "*For we walk by faith, not by sight*" (2 Corinthians 5:7, NKJV).

In Galatians 2:20, the Apostle Paul makes this reassuring statement regarding his sanctification, "*I am crucified with Christ, nevertheless I live, yet not I but Christ liveth in me, and the life I now live in the flesh, I live by **the faith of the Son of God** who loved me and gave himself for me*" (KJV). Paul states that the faith that he lives by is actually the **faith of Christ**, the Son of God, Who indwells him in the Person of the Holy Spirit. It seems that we can conclude that the faith with which God gifts us comes by virtue of the very life of Christ that lives within us. We have heard many times that our faith is not in **our faith** but in the object and source of our faith, Jesus Christ. Our natural faith may sometimes feel strong and at other times seem very weak, but the faith of Christ who lives within us is always perfectly strong and

unfailing because His life within is always strong and unfailing.

In a recent Global Missions podcast, Bro. Terry Zimmer reminded us that when we gave our heart to Jesus, He came in His fullness and His completeness. We did not receive a partial Jesus but the perfect, all-powerful and complete Jesus in the Person of His Holy Spirit and the One whose resources are inexhaustible for any challenge we may face.

Watchman Nee, the Chinese theologian has stated, and I paraphrase, that it is not enough for us to just have this Life within us; there must be a demand or call upon this Life or it will not be manifested. The word manifest means to make clear or evident, show plainly. For our faith to be clear, evident and shown plainly, there must be a demand put upon it. In John 16:33, Jesus said, *“These things I have spoken to you, that in Me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation; but be of good cheer, I have overcome the world”* (NKJV).

The following comes from Strong's Lexicon 2347, “The term *“thlipsis”* (Gk - tribulation) is used in the New Testament to describe a state of severe distress or suffering, often due to external pressures or persecution. It conveys the idea of being under intense pressure or in a state of affliction, whether physical, emotional, or spiritual. In a biblical context, it often refers to the trials and hardships faced by believers as a result of their faith.”

The life of Christ within us is able to meet every demand to which it is subjected, and without such demand, the totally sufficient power of the Lord in us might never be expressed through us. Jesus tells us even in the face of tribulation to be of good cheer because He has overcome everything the world and the prince of this world can throw at us. In James 1:2-6, we read, *“My brethren,*

count it all joy when you fall into various trials, knowing that the testing of your faith produces patience. But let patience have its perfect work, that you may be perfect and complete, lacking nothing. If any of you lacks wisdom, let him ask of God, who gives to all liberally and without reproach, and it will be given to him. But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for he who doubts is like a wave of the sea driven and tossed by the wind” (NKJV).

During our walk of faith, the demands on the Christ-life within us will continuously increase. Jesus told us in His Sermon on the Mount as recorded in Matthew 7:13-14, (NKJV), *“Enter by the narrow gate; for wide is the gate and broad is the way that leads to destruction, and there are many who go in by it. Because narrow is the gate and difficult is the way which leads to life, and there are few who find it.”* The power of the Christ-life within us will always exceed the demand made upon it. However, it is too often the self-life that becomes an obstruction to the release of the Christ-life within. It is not just our mean self-life but also our so-called religious self-life, our attempts to be and do good in our natural strength and self-determination. Remember, *“Blessed are the poor in spirit for theirs is the kingdom of heaven”* (Matthew 5:3, NKJV). There may also be specific hindrances which obstruct the release of the Christ-life such as self-will, disobedience, thinking more highly of ourselves than we ought to think, etc. Surely we must confess and repent of these things, and this is what the cross of Christ is for. *“For if we have been united together in the likeness of His death, certainly we also shall be in the likeness of His resurrection, knowing this, that our old man was crucified with Him, that the body of sin might be done away with, that we should no longer be slaves of sin. For he who has died has been freed from sin”* (Romans 6:5-7, NKJV).

Continued in the next issue. ✝

SEARCHING FOR GOD

DAN LEVSON

The King James Version is referenced unless indicated otherwise.

We, young or old, need to be constantly searching for God throughout every moment of every day. God has placed in each

man and woman, each boy and girl, a desire to know who God is. Some search for the Creator of all things in what they see around them. Some look for a force more powerful, and more wise than themselves, and even search for a spirit. Some feel the answers

can be found only in their own reasoning.

There are probably thousands of religions that try to answer the question of how to know who God is. How can we TRULY find Him the ONE, TRUE GOD? Jeremiah 29:13, *"And ye shall seek me, and find me, when ye shall search for me with all your heart."* Are there any requirements for this?

Hebrews 11:6, *"But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him."*

The first requirement is that you and I must believe there is a God. Then we must search diligently for Him. Diligent means to make a steady, earnest, and energetic effort. One of the best cold case detectives, was originally an atheist. When he studied Jesus' death and resurrection and everything written about Him in the Bible and history, he concluded that Jesus must be real and became a Christian.

The whole creation actually speaks of God because He made it. Romans 1:20, *"For the invisible things of Him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are made, even His eternal power and Godhead; so that they are without excuse:"* The second requirement is John 4:24, *"God is a Spirit: and they that worship Him must worship Him in spirit and in truth."* We must let the Holy Spirit guide us into all truth. This is a continual process, a little bit at a time.

The third requirement is to recognize the living God through his Son Jesus. John 1:14, *"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld His glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."*

How do we search to actually find God? There are many ways, but here are a few. Read, study, and memorize the Bible, letting the Holy Spirit reveal its true meaning, intentions and applications to our real, everyday life. The Bible is also often referred to as the Scriptures, the Word, etc. In summary, it is the **written** Word of God. There is also the **created** Word of God which is basically all of creation.

There is also the **living** Word of God which is Jesus. John 5:39 says, *"Search the scriptures; for in them ye think you have eternal life: and they are they which testify of Me."*

Another way of searching is recognizing our need for others who are Holy Spirit-filled and realizing they also need us. John 13:34 says, *"A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another."* 1 Corinthians 12:12, *"For as the body is one, and hath many members, and all the members of that one body, being many, are one body: so also is Christ."* 1 Corinthians 12:27, *"Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular."* Our need for one another cannot be stressed enough. Hebrews 10:25 says, *"Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some is; but exhorting one another: and so much the more, as ye see the day approaching."*

Another way of searching is talking to and listening to the Living God. It is done through prayer. Jesus taught us how to pray in Matthew 6:9-15. We can talk to Him about anything. We can tell Him how much we love, and adore Him. We can confess our sins and ask Him to forgive us and help us change. We can thank Him for as many things as possible including the hard things in life. We can ask Him to help us have a good attitude.

In conclusion, Matthew 7:7 says, *"Ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find; knock, and it shall be opened unto you."* 

GLOBAL MISSIONS INC.

Global Missions Inc. was founded in 1944, as a Christian mission to promote and encourage the preaching of the gospel to every creature.

Global Missions reaches into many countries in Africa, India, the Caribbean, the United States of America, South America and the Philippines. These local churches are established on the foundational truths revealed in God's word and through His unfolding revelation. Local churches are governed by local residents who are referred to as elders.

Global Missions is a nondenominational Christian church.

Headquarters:
802 Airport Road
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Mailing Address:
P.O. Box 934
North Battleford, SK S9A 2Z3 Canada

Telephone:
(306) 445-2733

Email:
info@globalmissionsinc.org

Online:
www.globalmissionsinc.org

Traveling Ministry Contact List:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/about

SHARON

The Sharon Star is a monthly publication and mailed as a free-will offering plan. The articles within are intended for inspiration and information to those who are interested in the unfolding revelation of the Word of God.

Published by:
Global Missions Inc. in North Battleford, Saskatchewan, Canada.

The Sharon Star is found online at:
www.globalmissionsinc.org/sharon-star

Publications Mail Agreement 40012206

Subscribe by mail or online.